

Chapter

Hear the Auspicious, See the Auspicious — The Hidden Power of Positivity



Introduction: A Familiar Mantra, an Unheard Meaning

Before the recitation of the Vedas and Upanishads, a peace mantra is chanted that many of us have heard countless times:

om̐ bhadraṁ karṇebhiḥ śṛṇuyāma devāḥ

bhadraṁ paśyemākṣabhir yajatrāḥ

"O gods, may we hear with our ears what is **bhadra** (auspicious, beneficial); O you who are worthy of worship, may we see with our eyes what is **bhadra**."

— Rig Veda 1.89.8 (Shanti Path)

Acharya Ji explains that every word of our scriptures deserves deep understanding, and that this mantra is only a preparation — the beginning of calming the mind:

"Each and every verse of ours, each and every word, will be very elaborate. Like 'om̐ bhadraṁ karṇebhiḥ śṛṇuyāma devāḥ'. So anyway this is preparation; your **atha** has not begun yet. Before that, calm the mind a little — that is what it says."

Atha — in the scriptures, this word marks the true beginning of a body of knowledge. The peace mantra is the doorway before it.

In this chapter Acharya Ji opens the two halves of this mantra — **hearing the auspicious** and **seeing the auspicious** — and shows that the real meaning of "positivity" goes far deeper than the one we usually assume.

The Usual Meaning of "Bhadra" — and the First Mistake

First Acharya Ji gives the simple meaning of the mantra's words:

"So we know **karna** means ear — something is being said about the ear. **Śṛṇu** means to listen, so it is something about listening with the ear."

"Saying **abhadra** means bad or wrong, so **bhadra** will mean good, auspicious. So 'May I always hear only the auspicious with my ears' — that is all that sentence says."

Everyone knows this much. But Acharya Ji immediately questions this popular understanding:

"So what have we been told until today? Meaning see good, do good, be good — likewise it would be hear good. That is not what it means."

Then what is **bhadra**?

"For my ears, **bhadra** is that whose result is good for me. What I hear has no connection at all with whether it feels good or bad. This is the first misunderstanding."

This is the key to the whole teaching: **bhadra is not what sounds pleasant; bhadra is what leads to a good result.**

Bitter Medicine Is Also Bhadra

Acharya Ji explains this through examples from daily life. The Guru's words often feel harsh:

"Today if the Guru's words feel like bitter medicine, even then they must be drunk. They are **bhadra** to hear, because actually their result is going to be **bhadra**."

The laws a king makes, or a traffic signal — these too are not pleasant, yet they are for our good:

"Today if a king makes some law and it is for your good — it will be a signal — then should you listen to the signal or not? It is good for you, even though it doesn't feel nice."

And the scolding at home and at school:

"Some teacher shouts at a student, a mother shouts at her son — that shouting is actually **bhadra** for him. So we should listen to it."

On the other hand, what is sweet to the ear is not necessarily **bhadra**:

"Whereas there will be some dirty song, or some bad play, or something wrong and shoddy — it probably even feels nice to hear. It will be a film song, or anything else."

Preya and Shreya

Here Acharya Ji points to a well-known distinction of the scriptures — **preya** (what is pleasing) and **shreya** (what is truly beneficial):

"What we call **preya** and **shreya** — **preya**, what feels dear to me, is not called **bhadra**. That whose result will be **bhadra** is **bhadra**. Understood or not?"

That is, **bhadra** belongs to **shreya**, not to **preya**. What pleases the ear may be **preya**; what uplifts one's life is **shreya**.

Hearing the Future: Bhadra or Abhadra?

Now Acharya Ji raises another subtle question — hearing the future from astrology and Nadi Shastra. The Yoga Sutras say:

heyaṁ duḥkham anāgatam

"The suffering that has not yet come is what is to be avoided."

— Patanjali Yoga Sutra 2.16

Acharya Ji gives its practical meaning:

"Like when we hear some Nadi Shastra or astrology — 'heyam duḥkham anāgatam' — for the suffering that has not even come, one should first hear what is going to come ahead. If it has been said ahead of time, then I will take some action."

But this very hearing backfires for many:

"Now the scripture has said 'heyam duḥkham anāgatam', but for many people it becomes abhadra, because they come to know the future in advance."

A Story: The Minister Who Wanted to Be King

To make this clear, Acharya Ji tells a story:

"There was a king, a good king, and he had good ministers. So one minister — as long as he was all right, things were all right. But some astrologers who say wrong, twisted things — the ones called witches in English — some such people come and tell him, 'You will become king ahead; you are the next king.'"

The moment he heard the prophecy, everything changed:

"Now as long as things were going fine, he was a good, capable minister. And as soon as he heard this prophecy — if it is a prophecy, then he was going to become king anyway, wasn't he? — his mind and his wife's mind went bad because of it."

"Now he thought, everything is fine, I will become king — but how? As long as this king is alive, I cannot be king. So they come up with a plan that he must be killed right now. And they actually kill the king."

And the result:

"After killing him, they later feel great remorse. Ghosts, spirits and demons seem to follow them around, and they make the life hell."

"So now, was his hearing this **bhadra** or **abhadra**?"

The prophecy that could have made him alert became the cause of his downfall — because what he did after hearing it was **abhadra**.

"My Liberation Is Confirmed" — the Trap of Ego

Acharya Ji also gives an example from a seeker's life. Suppose someone's **patrikā** (horoscope) shows a promise of spiritual progress:

"First one heard it; if one then began planning accordingly, one heard **bhadra**. And if someone did something like this — it came in someone's horoscope that 'after ten years I will help the Guru himself, my **moksha** is confirmed' — if hearing all this he became egoistic, it turned the other way..."

The real message of that prophecy is something else:

"Arey, but if after ten years the Guru has said so, what does it mean? In ten years I have to do something, from **sakhya bhakti** up to **ātma-samarpaṇa**; only after that, perhaps, will the Guru listen to you."

Sakhya bhakti — devotion in the mood of friendship towards God or the Guru; **ātma-samarpaṇa** — complete offering of oneself. The prophecy pointed to a long **sādhana**, but the egoist takes it as today's certificate:

"He feels that today itself he has become something, and if from today itself he starts behaving that way, then perhaps it will not happen even after ten years — the Guru will send him away right now."

So Acharya Ji concludes:

"So the result that was to come decides whether I heard **bhadra** or **abhadra**."

Markandeya: When Bitter Words Became a Blessing

On the other hand, if one hears and takes the right remedy, even the harshest news becomes **bhadra**:

"Similarly someone heard that you are going to have a heart attack ahead — the horoscope says after six years, after five years. As soon as he heard it: 'Gurudev, this and this has happened, what should I do? Do something for me, where did I go wrong?'"

And the most beautiful example of this is the story of the sage Markandeya, who was granted a lifespan of only sixteen years:

"Like when his father told him, 'There was such-and-such a boon, that you would be born to us as a short-lived son.' So don't take tension — the son himself tells them. He heard it. Had he not heard it, perhaps he would have died at sixteen."

"They spoke the bitter words, and for him it became **bhadra** — his lifespan became sixteen **kalpas**."

It was hard for the parents to say and hard for the son to hear — but hearing it opened the way to a remedy, and a short life turned into a long one.

Phalashruti: The Journey from Nara to Narayana

So in the end, what does **bhadra** depend on? Acharya Ji connects it to **phalashruti** — the fruit of a spiritual practice:

"Now on what does this **bhadra** depend — '**bhadraṁ karṇebhiḥ śṛṇuyāma devāḥ**' — do you understand? What is its **phalashruti**? What you do with it, your net outcome — whether your going from **nara** to **Nārāyaṇa** happens or not — that decides whether you have heard **bhadra** or not."

This is the essence of the mantra's first half: **the hearing that carries you from nara (man) towards Nārāyaṇa (God) is the hearing of bhadra.**

Seeing Bhadra: Yajna Bhava in Everything

Now the mantra's second half — "**bhadraṁ paśyemākṣabhir yajatrāḥ**":

"**Bhadra** means good, **paśya** means to see. So what is it called to see good? So **yajatrāḥ** — **yaja** means **yajña**. Wherever I see **yajña bhāva**, wherever I see sacrifice."

Here **yajña bhāva** means the sacrifice, toil and dedication hidden behind anything. Acharya Ji gives a startling example:

"Where I even happened to see a dirty film by mistake — leave aside watching deliberately, that is out of the question; even if I saw it by mistake — why do you look at the rest of the heroine's body? Look at how much **yajña** she must have done, how much sacrifice, to maintain that body — look at that much."

"Even in the wrong thing that came before my eyes only by mistake, is there **yajña** or not?"

That is, the moment the vision changes, the very sight that could have dragged the mind down becomes a reason for respect.

A Road, a Building, Art — and the Guru's Knowledge

Acharya Ji teaches us to see **yajña bhāva** in everyday things:

"You saw a road — very good. To build the road, how many poor people must have shown some **yajña bhāva**, how much sacrifice they must have made. If that is not seen, then nothing **bhadra** was seen."

"Whatever thing has come into my hands — how many people laboured for it, how much **yajña bhāva** went into it."

And above all, the knowledge received from the Guru:

"When the Guru is giving you this knowledge, it means how much **jñāna yajña** has come down through the Guru tradition, the tradition of the rishis, that I am receiving. If one did not see this — with a selfish attitude, 'I got it, done, let's go' — he has seen nothing at all; he has gone away having seen only **abhadra**, the one who did not see the **yajña**."

Buildings, idols, paintings — the same vision in all of them:

"You saw a big building — what does it mean? The hard work of so many people. There is some idol, some art, a painting — its **yajña bhāva** should be seen in it."

"Not just the time spent on the painting — how much **yajña bhāva** must have gone into gaining the expertise for that painting. If this is not seen, then you have not seen **bhadra**; you have seen **abhadra**."

The Gita's Proof: Everything Is Established in Yajna

Why should one see this way? Acharya Ji answers from the Bhagavad Gita:

"So Krishna himself told it in the Bhagavad Gita, didn't he — that the Vedas arose from the Supreme itself, and through the Vedas everything comes. ... And from **yajña** itself the rain, nature and everything else is created, from where all facilities come."

annād bhavanti bhūtāni parjanyaḥ anna-
sambhavaḥ
yajñād bhavati parjanyo yajñaḥ karma-
samudbhavaḥ
karma brahmodbhavaṁ viddhi brahmākṣara-
samudbhavam
tasmāt sarva-gataṁ brahma nityaṁ yajñe
pratiṣṭhitam

"All beings arise from food; food arises from rain;
rain arises from yajña; and yajña arises from
prescribed action. Know that the whole of action
arises from the Veda, and that the Veda arises from
the imperishable Supreme. Therefore the all-
pervading, supreme, imperishable Brahman is ever
established in yajña."

— Bhagavad Gita 3.14–15

Acharya Ji opens up the words of these verses. Parjanya, or rain, is not just rainfall:

"Meaning from **parjanya**; it represents the nature, not just rain."

Yajña is not just the fire ritual but **yajña bhāva**:

"**Yajña** means **yajña bhāva**; if something sattvic, everything with sacrifice, is going on, then it happens."

Vihita karma — action prescribed by the scriptures:

"**Vihita** means the work that is ordained — that is **vihita**; and **rahita** means what is not in the scriptures."

And the **Veda**:

"Veda means that divine knowledge which was eternal."

Hence the conclusion:

"So if I am to see, I should see **yajña bhāva**. So '**bhadraṁ paśyemākṣabhir yajatrāḥ**'. If **yajña bhāva** is not seen anywhere at all, then I have not seen God's creation."

Since the Supreme Itself is established in **yajña**, to see the **yajña** behind anything is to see God in it.

Why Envy at Seeing Wealth?

This vision also protects us from envy:

"Even if you see the richest of the rich, don't look at his luxurious bungalow and all that. Behind it, how much **tapasyā** he, his family, his lineage must have done — if that **yajña bhāva** was not seen, then **abhadra** was seen."

"Now seeing that, you will have some other trouble — jealousy will come, trouble will come — or you will try to copy him."

That is, seeing only outer splendour is **abhadra** seeing — it gives birth only to jealousy or blind imitation.

There Is Negative Yajna Too

Acharya Ji makes it clear that **yajña bhāva** is not found only in good deeds — sacrifice is needed even in the wrong

direction:

"Come on, I'll tell you — even earning black money takes a lot of **yajña**, you know? But that will be a negative thing. Just as there is a **yajña** even for a mantra of dark energy, isn't there? There is."

"Likewise a terrorist too needs **yajña bhāva** to become big. ... But we are not endorsing it; still, it too will need **yajña**. Kansa and Ravana too performed **yajñas**."

Acharya Ji does not support this — he only shows that **yajña** means sacrifice, and it is the direction of the sacrifice that makes it divine or demonic.

Soldier, Sportsman, Film — See the Yajna, Not the Result

That is why Acharya Ji says not to take **yajña** as ritual alone:

"So leave aside talk of physical, symbolic **yajña** — it actually means sacrifice. So your soldier who gives his life for the country — his **yajña bhāva** should be seen."

"When there is a sportsman, don't look only at today's century — look at the **yajña bhāva**."

Success and failure are in the hands of **prārabdha**, but toil deserves respect in every case:

"A picture becomes a hit, becomes a flop — don't just say 'it flopped'; there were so many people behind it flopping too. That is **prārabdha** — sometimes it will be a hit, sometimes a flop; sometimes one will win a match, sometimes lose; sometimes someone will win an election, lose. What is to be seen behind it? **Yajña bhāva**."

Prārabdha — the fruit of past actions that is to be lived out in this life.

Mother's Laddoo

And finally, the closest example of all — the mother:

"Likewise today's laddoo — mother made it, the son likes it. But how the mother raised him, the sacrifice she made — if that **yajña bhāva** was not seen, then the son saw everything as **abhadra**. He did not see anything good, anything auspicious in his mother at all."

The taste of the laddoo is only **preya**; to see the mother's years of sacrifice behind it — that is the seeing of **bhadra**.

Summary: The Main Teachings

- 1 Bhadra is not what feels good; bhadra is what leads to a good result.** "Hear good" does not mean hearing sweet words.
- 2 Bitter words can also be bhadra.** The Guru's harsh speech, the scolding of mother and teacher, laws and signals — all are for our good.
- 3 Distinguish preya from shreya.** What pleases is **preya**; **bhadra** belongs to **shreya**.

- 4 **What you do after hearing makes it bhadra or abhadra.** The minister who killed the king after hearing a prophecy, and the seeker who grew egoistic thinking "my moksha is confirmed" — both heard abhadra. For Markandeya, who heard and took the remedy, even bitter words became a blessing.
- 5 **The test is the journey from nara to Nārāyaṇa.** The hearing that leads you that way is bhadra.
- 6 **Seeing bhadra means seeing the yajña bhāva behind everything** — in a road, a building, art, the Guru's knowledge, the soldier, the sportsman and the mother's sacrifice.
- 7 **The Supreme is ever established in yajña** (Gita 3.14–15). So seeing yajña bhāva is itself seeing God's creation.
- 8 **Seeing outer splendour is abhadra seeing** — it breeds jealousy and blind imitation. See the tapasyā behind it.
- 9 **Yajña means sacrifice, and its direction matters.** Negative deeds also take yajña, but they are not endorsed.

10 The result is in the hands of prārabdha; respect for effort is in yours. Hit or flop, win or loss — see the yajña bhāva.